

L'Opera — Opera as a Second Language

Capsule Culturale · L'Opera · Cultural · Any level · 6 sessions × 60 min

The Promise

Six live cultural sessions on Verdi, Puccini and Rossini. Read a libretto, follow an aria, and understand why Italians still cry at La Scala.

On Completion, You Can:

- › Read a Verdi or Puccini libretto in Italian
- › Follow an aria and grasp its meaning in real time
- › Understand the vocabulary of opera — voci, ruoli, registri, ripiene
- › Talk about opera history from the Camerata to Verismo
- › Attend a live opera and understand the plot without subtitles
- › Discuss a performance in Italian with a fellow enthusiast

The Syllabus — Week by Week

Lesson 01 · La nascita dell'opera

Florence, 1600 — the Camerata de' Bardi and the invention of opera. Vocabulary of stagecraft.

Lesson 02 · Rossini — il Barbiere di Siviglia

Reading and singing along to Largo al factotum. Comic opera vocabulary.

Lesson 03 · Verdi — La Traviata

Reading Libiamo ne' lieti calici. Verdi as national poet.

Lesson 04 · Verdi — Aida e Nabucco

The political operas. Va, pensiero as second national anthem.

Lesson 05 · Puccini — La Bohème

Reading Che gelida manina. The verismo revolution and the vocabulary of Parisian bohemia.

Lesson 06 · Puccini — Turandot

Reading Nessun dorma. The final Puccini opera and its cultural afterlife. Cultural graduation.